Lento vs. Duolingo: Prototype Usability Evaluation & 5-Participant Comparative Review

1. Executive Summary & General Consensus

This document provides a comprehensive synthesis of user feedback, comparative analysis, and verbatim transcripts from 5 evaluators comparing **Lento** (a Figma prototype designed by Daivik Sheth) directly with Duolingo.

Overall Usability Consensus

Lento is evaluated as an intentional, adult, and mindful alternative to hyper-gamified language platforms. Across all five reviewers, Lento's calm aesthetic, low-pressure philosophy, authentic real-world Spanish context, transparent curriculum roadmap, and non-punitive error mechanics received high praise. Users appreciated learning in an environment that respects mental clarity rather than bombarding them with flashing animations, streak freezes, and commercial upsells.

However, participants unanimously highlighted significant gaps that prevent Lento from replacing Duolingo as an everyday habit:

1. Complete lack of voice/speech recognition and oral pronunciation testing.
2. An over-reliance on predictable multiple-choice questions.
3. Absence of daily motivation or gentle retention loops, causing Lento to feel at times like self-directed "digital homework."
4. Overly clinical analytics that resemble a "stock portfolio" rather than a supportive learning tracker.

The Fundamental Philosophical Contrast

- **Duolingo**: High-energy, gamified, dopamine-driven, and colorful. Leverages streaks, leagues, chests, and push notifications to drive daily engagement. However, its punitive hearts/lives system, abrupt failure screens, persistent Super upsells, and nonsensical sentences (e.g., green bears drinking milk) create fatigue and performance anxiety.
- **Lento**: Calm, dark-themed, grounded, and educational. Prioritizes deep comprehension (*"Understanding first, speed can wait"*), practical real-world fluency (cafes, forums, social media), transparent linear roadmaps (Units 2–4 with explicit outcome objectives), and constructive error breakdowns without penalties. However, it lacks daily habit-forming hooks and interactive voice practice.

2. Synthesized Review: Likes vs. Dislikes across All 5 Participants

What Users Liked About Lento

- **Mindful, Mature Visual Design**: Dark mode, muted green accents, and serif headings create an elegant, focused interface that is restful on the eyes compared to Duolingo's cartoonish, high-saturation UI.
- **Respect for Mental Space (Anti-Casino Energy)**: Completely eliminates flashing chests, streak freeze emergencies, countdown timers, and aggressive upsells for premium subscriptions.
- **Supportive, Low-Pressure Tone**: Principles like *"Understanding first, speed can wait"* and *"Progress without pressure"* remove learning anxiety, especially for beginners.
- **Authentic, Real-World Spanish Context**: Mini-games and lessons simulate realistic everyday scenarios (ordering coffee politely at a cafe, analyzing social media posts, reading community forums) instead of abstract or absurd sentences.
- **Pedagogical Feedback without Punitive Lives**: When users answer incorrectly, Lento does not subtract lives or show abrupt red screens. Instead, it unpacks grammatical nuances and provides alternative practical takeaway phrases.
- **Transparent Linear Curriculum**: Clear progression through visible units (Units 2, 3, 4) with clear status badges ("Completed", "Up Next") and explicit *"By the end of this unit"* outcome objectives.
- **Comprehensive Accessibility Suite**: Built-in high contrast, colorblind mode, screen-reader compatibility, large text, increased line spacing, and untimed practice.
- **Detailed Graphical Statistics**: Replaces simple streak counters with analytical data graphs tracking user mastery.

What Users Disliked / Identified as Critical Improvements

- **Absence of Interactive Speaking/Voice Tools**: No microphone input or speech-to-text pronunciation assessment, which all testers consider essential for true language mastery.
- **Predictable Exercise Formats**: Heavy reliance on multiple-choice questions reduces active recall and challenge.
- **Lack of Daily Retention & Habit Hooks**: Without streaks, milestones, or subtle engagement nudges, learners lack the daily "dopamine lock-in" that keeps them returning.
- **Clinical "Stock Portfolio" Analytics**: Statistics dashboards and dense data graphs can feel overly technical, cold, or formal for language learning.
- **Prototype Scope Constraints**: Static navigation locked to a single language track (Spanish with persona Maya Chen) without language switching.
- **Accessibility Feature Placement**: Invaluable accessibility toggles are nested at the bottom of the user profile page rather than in a visible, easily accessible menu.
- **Cognitive Text Density**: Explanatory feedback cards can present large walls of text, which may feel heavy during quick review sessions.

3. Comprehensive Feature Comparison Matrix

Feature / Dimension	Lento (Devik Seth Prototype)	Duolingo
Target Audience & Tone	Serious adult learners; calm, dignified, low-pressure focus.	Broad audience of all ages; energetic, playful, highly gamified.
Visual Aesthetic	Dark mode, green accents, serif typography, minimalist UI.	Bright primary colors, cartoon illustrations, animated owl mascot.
Monetization & Prompts	Clean, uninterrupted interface with no commercial interruptions.	Frequent popups, Super Duolingo upsells, full-screen ads.
Error Handling & Feedback	No lives lost; pauses to explain grammatical errors with practical takeaways.	Punitive heart/lives system; abrupt red screens; rushes to next question.
Curriculum Realism	Real-world practical scenarios (cafes, social forums, news snippets).	Repetitive vocabulary drills, frequently featuring nonsensical sentences.
Unit Navigation	Linear roadmap with visible forward units and explicit objective boxes.	Winding, locked path with obscured future progress.
Audio & Speaking	Audio playback only; no speech evaluation or oral input.	Comprehensive speech recognition, oral repetition, listening drills.
Retention Mechanics	Self-directed; clean progress graphs; no streaks or leaderboards.	Daily streaks, streak freezes, leagues, leaderboards, daily quests.
Accessibility Support	Built-in high contrast, colorblind modes, screen reader, untimed exercises.	Basic system-level accessibility; limited custom UI adjustments.

4. Strategic Recommendations for Lento's Roadmap

1. **Implement Oral Speech & Pronunciation Recognition**: Add interactive speaking drills with audio waveform feedback to address the most urgent competitive gap.

2. **Diversify Practice Mechanics**: Introduce interactive drag-and-drop sentence building, fill-in-the-blank typing, and pair matching to reduce multiple-choice predictability.
3. **Introduce Mindful Habit-Building Milestones**: Implement non-punitive consistency tracking (e.g., weekly rhythm goals, gentle milestone badges) that encourage regular study without creating streak anxiety.
4. **Elevate Accessibility Settings**: Move accessibility toggles to the primary navigation bar or header modal for immediate discovery.
5. **Humanize Statistics & Feedback**: Use progressive disclosure (expandable cards) for deep grammar tips, and pair data graphs with warm milestone visual markers.

5. Individual Participant Transcripts & Detailed Summaries

Participant 1: Ayush Rai

- **Profile**: TYBTech AI-DS Panel C 1262243477
- **Summary**:
    - Praised Lento's calm, dark-themed, minimalist UI with serif headings and green accents.
    - Strongly endorsed the low-pressure learning philosophy ("Understanding first, speed can wait").
    - Appreciated the clear lesson structure, progress bars, and educational feedback (e.g., Spanish cafe ordering).
    - Recommended making accessibility settings more discoverable rather than placing them at the bottom of the profile page.

"Hello everyone, I am Ayush Rai, currently studying in MIT-WPU third year, AI-DS Panel C, and today I'll be comparing the app developed by Daivik Sheth, Lento, with Duolingo and seeing which one got the edge over which.Hello, today I'll be discussing the UI/UX of a Spanish learning app, Lento, and comparing it with Duolingo. One of the first things I noticed about Lento is its calm and minimalist design. From what I can see, it uses a dark theme, green accents, and serif headings, which gives it a clean and focused appearance, something which I really appreciate, because I'm already very used to these formal and excessive UI/UX designed by most of the web services out there.The overall tone is also less pressuring, with phrases like 'Understanding first, speed can wait' and 'Small steps to real understanding'. I think this could make learning more comfortable, especially for beginners. However, I would also like to know whether users find this supportive or whether they prefer Duolingo's more energetic approach. Personally, for me, I would think Lento is just better in this aspect, because when you're learning something new, especially something critical or hard like a language, Lento, I would say, gives it a better approach over there.Another positive point is the lesson structure. The lessons page clearly shows completed lessons, the next lesson, and upcoming lessons. The progress bar also makes it easier to understand how much of the unit is completed. Comparing it with Duolingo's learning path, this structure might make it easier for users to understand where they are and what they need to do next. Again, Lento has an

edge over here.And if we're coming back to the feedback system, instead of simply marking an answer as correct or incorrect, Lento explains why the answer is right or wrong and provides another useful phrase. For example, from what I have got, in the cafe lesson, it explains how to politely order coffee in Spanish. This makes the experience more educational, although the feedback screen can sometimes contain quite a lot of text, which could be overwhelming, but it is necessary from what I believe.Another major advantage is accessibility. Lento offers features such as high contrast, colorblind mode, screen reader support, captions, large text, increased line spacing, and untimed practices. These options can make the app more comfortable for different users. However, the accessibility settings are located near the bottom of the profile page, so from what I believe, the developer can make accessing those settings a little bit easier. And that will be all from my side."

Participant 2: Sukhnidhi Kaur

- **Profile**: BTech AI-DS Panel C 1262243482
- **Summary**:
    - Preferred Lento's frontend styling over Duolingo's, noting Duolingo feels tailored for children while Lento has a mature, technical vibe.
    - Pointed out that Lento currently has only one static language/persona (Maya Chen learning Spanish) and needs multi-language support.
    - Praised the mini-games and lessons for using realistic everyday situations (social media posts, news forums) instead of abstract quizzes.
    - Believes Lento is superior for fast, practical, fluent learning, while Duolingo offers more grammatical depth and language variety.
    - Commended the statistics page with graphs in Lento versus Duolingo's basic streak tracking.

"My name is Sukhnidhi Kaur and I am from Panel C, BTech AI-DS, and I am reviewing Daivik's UI/UX project on Duolingo-based language learning website.So comparing both the apps side by side, I really like the front end of Lento in comparison to Duolingo. Duolingo is designed more for maybe children, but Lento, I feel this gives a more technical vibe.On the other hand, Duolingo has, I feel, more data sets in comparison to Lento, because I can't find an option to change languages, but I think Lento has a very static... I see Maya Chen is trying to learn Spanish, so there is just one... like only one thing that we can navigate. I don't see an option to change languages in between.But exploring the mini-games part, I think this is quite different in comparison to Duolingo, because Duolingo has more of a quiz outlook, but Lento has different types... like such quizzes that will help you in real life, which is more necessary, like social media posts, news forums, and stuff, which is more helpful.If I explore the lessons part, even the lessons part is more creative, because all those phrases that you'll be using in your daily life, the chapters are built according to that.So I feel Lento is built in a way that if you want to learn the language very fluently and very easily and as fast as possible, Lento is very good in comparison to Duolingo. Lento can be preferred, but if you want to know the depth in the language, then Duolingo might have an edge over Lento. Otherwise, Duolingo will always have an edge over Lento because there are more

languages that we can navigate to, so that is one difference.In comparison to... okay, we have an option of statistics, which I feel Duolingo also provides in the profile option, but again, the difference in statistics is that Lento has a much better UI. Your statistics is being represented in the form of graphs, but Duolingo just provides the streaks and your current contribution.Yeah, that's it from my side."

Participant 3: Priyank Tripathi

- **Profile**: TYBTech AI-DS Panel D 1262243517
- **Summary**:
    - Criticized Lento's question variety: feels restricted to predictable multiple-choice questions without real-life challenge.
    - Emphasized the critical absence of speaking and voice practice in Lento compared to Duolingo's speech recognition.
    - Commended accessibility features (colorblind mode, contrast, screen reader) as rare for language apps.
    - UI looks very good, though the green vs orange/red accent balance had mixed reactions.
    - Praised Duolingo's superior gamification (streaks, quests, leaderboards) and felt Lento's rewards need significant enhancement.
    - Strongly endorsed Lento's calm, low-pressure tone ("Understanding first, speaking can wait", "Progress without pressure") as far more supportive than Duolingo's aggressive nudges.

"Hello, my name is Priyank Tripathi, and I'm from Panel D, AI-DS, and I'll be reviewing Daivik's UI/UX project on Duolingo.And if I had to compare something like the question types, Lento is lagging behind as compared to Duolingo. It's just a bunch of multiple-choice questions which feel very predictable to answer and are not much useful in a real-life scenario. On the other hand, Duolingo is much more precise and easier to use, and actually has a voice function to listen to your own voice. Other than that, there's no actual way to practice your speaking in Lento, if you compare that to Duolingo where you can actually test your voice.And though I would definitely say the colorblind mode, contrast, and the screen reader options are very rare in something like language apps, and the UI actually looks really good for Lento, though the green versus orange-red is a bit mixed opinion, but I think it's still workable.And something that's definitely better about Duolingo as compared to Lento is that Duolingo definitely has a very good way to reward you with your streaks, with your quests, with your leaderboards, while the only thing Lento has is the statistics and the mini-games at best, which is fine, but it definitely has a lot of potential to be better.Finally, to end it on a positive note, I think the calm, low-pressure tone of Lento, with something like 'Understanding first, speaking can wait' and 'Progress without pressure', feels much more supportive and easier to follow as compared to Duolingo's motivational nudges, if you can say that. So yeah, that's my review on the comparison between Lento and Duolingo. Thank you."

Participant 4: Vedant Pachisia

- **Profile**: TYBTech ECE B 1262242352
- **Summary**:
    - Liked Lento's compact, minimalist UI that is easy on the eyes with good contrast.
    - Noted that Duolingo creates a strong "dopamine loop" that locks users in for 1–2 hours of continuous gamified play, whereas Lento is self-paced and lacks habit-forming hooks.
    - Appreciated Lento's variety of mini-games and incorporation of real-world situations.
    - Pointed out that Lento's statistics tab looks and feels like a "stock portfolio", which comes across as a bit too serious and formal for a language learning app.
    - Concluded that Lento loads fast and looks clean, but feels like "digital homework" rather than a game; would use Lento occasionally for real-world Spanish snippets, but wouldn't replace Duolingo for daily practice.

"Hello, this is Vedant Pachisia reviewing Devik's project on Duolingo-based website.The UI is something new. It's a bit more compact, minimalist look, easier on the eyes if we compare it to Duolingo, given the high contrast and the colors it brings.Duolingo keeps me more locked in. For example, on a day if I'm doing absolutely nothing, I can just log onto Duolingo and sit through one or two hours of games, mini-games, which involves language learning. Whereas Lento is a bit off the pace, I can do it whenever I want to. It's not by choice, but if I feel like it, I might just do it. It doesn't keep me as locked in as Duolingo does, and I think that's one of the drawbacks for a website like this.The one thing I like about Lento is the variety of mini-games and how it incorporates real-life situations, which helps enhance learning the language, and I think that's something different from Duolingo, which is a really plus-point factor.So the statistics tab of Lento makes me feel like I'm looking at a stock portfolio, which for a language learning website is a bit off, where I want it to be kind of chill, where I kind of want it to be fun. I really understand the path that it takes to make you feel like you have to learn it, it's a bit on the serious tone, but there could be changes with the whole vibe of Lento.For finishing up, Lento loads fast and looks clean, but it feels like digital homework rather than a game. Duolingo wins my daily use because of my dopamine loop. I could see myself using Lento occasionally to read real-world Spanish snippets, but it won't replace Duolingo for quick daily sessions."

Participant 5: Aanvi Bindal

- **Profile / PRN**: TYBTech AI-DS Panel F 1262243296
- **Summary**:
    - Praised the fundamental shift in design philosophy: Lento eliminates Duolingo’s frantic, casino-like energy, flashing chests, streak freezes, and persistent popups trying to upsell "Super".

- Commended Lento’s linear unit layout over Duolingo’s obscure, locked winding path; appreciated being able to scan ahead through Units 2, 3, and 4 with status badges ("Completed", "Up Next").
- Highlighted the "By the end of this unit" objective box as a smart addition that gives learners clear context on practical learning outcomes.
- Loved Lento's non-punitive feedback mechanics: instead of losing hearts and facing abrupt red failure screens, Lento pauses, deconstructs grammar errors, and provides takeaway phrases.
- Praised the authentic mini-games featuring Spanish in the wild over Duolingo's nonsensical cartoon phrases (e.g., green bears drinking milk).
- Concluded that Devik did a fantastic job designing an experience that genuinely respects learner mental space.

"Hello, I'm Aanvi, Aanvi Bindal, and my PRN is 1262243296. Today I'm going to review Daivik Sheth's prototype, Lento, which is a prototype for Duolingo.So I spent some time looking at his prototype and I compared it side by side with the actual Duolingo website, and honestly, I like the shift in design philosophy, and it's actually quite obvious the second I compare both of them together. When Duolingo hits me with flashing chests, streak freezes, and persistent popups trying to upsell me on the Super, his prototype feels intentionally calm and grounded. It has also eliminated that frantic casino-like energy in favor of something that respects the learner's mental space.Now while closely looking at the navigation in this prototype, I can see the linear unit layout is a massive improvement over Duolingo's winding path. On Duolingo, half the map is locked or obscured, so we never really know what's coming, but in the layout of the prototype, I can stand straight through Unit 2, 3, and 4, and there are status badges like 'Completed', 'Up Next', making the orientation very effortless.Adding that 'By the end of this unit' objectives box is another smart touch, unlike Duolingo. It gives the user explicit content on what practical outcome they're actually working towards.And once we enter a lesson, the feedback mechanics are where the prototype really shines. On Duolingo, if we make a mistake, it drops a heart, gives an abrupt red screen, and rushes through without any explanation. But the prototype has completely removed the stress of running out of lives. When someone gets a wrong answer, like confusing different words, the system takes a breath and unpacks the grammar guide, giving a takeaway phrase so that the users can actually learn from the error instead of feeling punished.And I also like the mini-games hub, which is a major step forward in authenticity. Instead of Duolingo's nonsensical sentences about the green bears drinking milk, the modules in this prototype features actual Spanish you would see in the wild.Overall, the prototype is much better than the actual Duolingo website, and I think Daivik has done a fab job."